OPEN LETTER · EYE ON SHOALHAVEN COUNCIL

CEO asked to confirm who filled Shoalhaven's $120,707 Strategic Relations Advisor role

Sent 7 July 2026 · To Council Email · Response requested by 28 July 2026

7 July 2026

Open Letter to the Chief Executive Officer of Shoalhaven City Council
RE: Strategic Relations Advisor — Request for Confirmation of Appointment, Professional Background and Brief

Dear Mr Constance,

I write in the knowledge that correspondence from this publication has, in recent months, been declined on the basis of guidance relating to unreasonable conduct. I note, for the record, that the application of that guidance to a public interest publication with more than 3,800 local readers is itself a matter currently before the NSW Ombudsman. The questions in this letter are not personal complaints. They are questions of public administration, put openly, on behalf of a readership that represents approximately 5.1 per cent of Shoalhaven's registered voters. They are questions any member of the public could put at an ordinary council meeting. I put them here, in writing, on the public record — and will publish whatever response is received, including none.

On 24 February 2026, Councillor Jemma Tribe put a Question on Notice to Council (CL26.20) about the newly advertised Strategic Relations Advisor position — a permanent, full-time role within the Chief Executive Office, advertised at $105,927 to $120,707 gross per annum plus 12 per cent superannuation. Cr Tribe asked for a briefing on whether a restructure was underway to include the position, and for assurance that it would not be a political appointment.

Your written response did not address either question directly. It stated that you were "aware that some misinformation is circulating online, driven by an individual acting with dishonourable intent," before asserting that the appointment would be conducted strictly in line with recruitment requirements and would be entirely merit-based. That response is on the public record in the minutes of that meeting.

This publication reported, cautiously and without naming anyone, that a name associated with South Coast Liberal politics was circulating locally as a possible applicant.

We did not assert that as fact, and we do not now.

Word since reaching us is that this was not, in fact, the successful applicant, and that whoever has been appointed has a considerably more senior professional background than the informal "media advisor" description first attached to the role — spanning close

to two decades in strategic communications, public policy and stakeholder engagement across multiple sectors.

We are not asking you to confirm or deny any name, and we are not seeking any personal or private information about the successful candidate — not their home address, family circumstances, or anything of that nature.

What we are asking for is the category of information ratepayers are ordinarily entitled to about a senior, publicly funded appointment sitting inside the Chief Executive Office:

- the candidate's relevant professional experience, and
- the brief they have been engaged to carry out.
- Given the role's proximity to both the Mayor and the CEO, and its explicit remit to advise on "political dynamics" and manage stakeholder relationships, this is squarely a matter of public interest rather than private employment detail.

I ask that you answer the following questions on the public record:

1. Has the Strategic Relations Advisor position been filled and, if so, from what date?
2. What is the successful candidate's relevant professional background — sector experience, qualifications and prior public-facing or communications roles? To be clear, this is not a request for personal or private information of any kind. It is a request for the category of professional information routinely published for senior public appointments, and it is a matter of legitimate public interest given the seniority, cost and influence of the role.
3. What is the specific brief the successful candidate has been engaged to deliver — the position description, key deliverables, and the measures they will be assessed against?
4. Who does the role report to — the CEO, the Mayor, or both — and what governance arrangements apply to that dual reporting relationship?
5. What was the panel composition and probity arrangement for the recruitment process, and was an independent panel member involved?
6. What is the full annual cost of the position, including superannuation and any other on-costs?
7. Can the CEO confirm whether the role's functions extend to political, reputational or crisis-management advice, or whether they are limited to routine public communications?

Council has already told residents, through Cr Tribe's question, that this role was previously considered and rejected under the former CEO on the basis that councillors, the Mayor and the CEO should manage political monitoring themselves.

Residents are entitled to know why that judgment has changed, what this appointment is intended to achieve, and what safeguards exist to ensure it serves public communication

rather than political or reputational management.

I will publish this letter, and whatever response, if any, is received.

Yours faithfully,

Steve Prothero
Publisher, Steve Prothero on Substack — Shoalhaven City Council coverage

Note to councillors receiving a copy of this letter: The questions above are put to the CEO on the public record. If you believe they warrant answers, you are in a position to raise them directly in the chamber — through a Question on Notice, a Notice of Motion, or a question to the CEO in open council. That is one of the most effective ways to place these matters on the public record in a forum where a response cannot be declined. This publication will report whatever is raised and whatever is answered.
